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8.5 Proteins

Proteins are the most diverse of all macromolecule. Proteins make up 2/3 of total dry mass of a cell. The term protein was coined by **Gerardus Johannes Mulder** and is derived form a *greek* word proteos which means of the first rank.

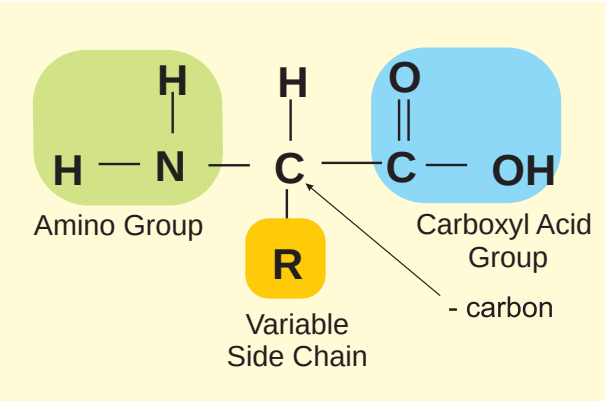


Figure 8.18: Structure of basic amino acid

Amino acids are building blocks of proteins. There are about 20 different amino acids exist naturally. All amino acids have a basic skeleton consisting of a carbon (a-carbon) linked to a basic amino group.

(NH_2), an acidic carboxylic group (COOH) and a hydrogen atom (H) and side chain or variable R group. The amino acid is both an acid and a base and is called **amphoteric**.

A **zwitterion** also called as **dipolar ion**, is a molecule with two or more functional groups, of which at least one has a positive and other has a negative electrical charge and the net charge of the entire molecule is zero. The pH at which this happens is known as the **isoelectric point** (Figure 8.19).

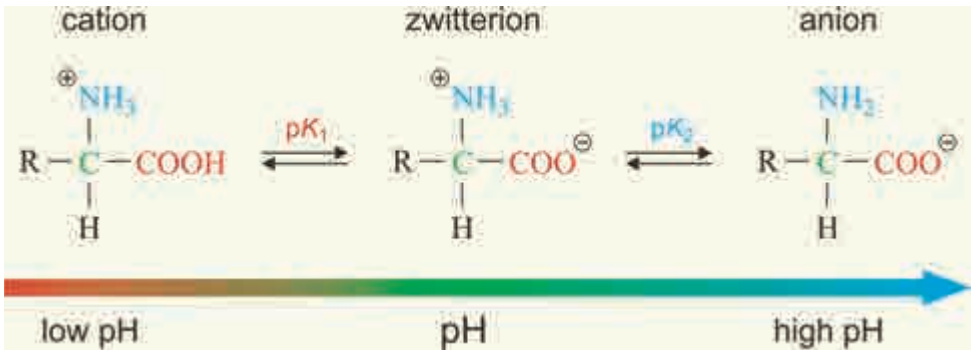


Figure 8.19: Structure of amino acid

8.5.1 Classification of Amino acids

Based on the R group amino acids are classified as acidic, basic, polar, non-polar.

The amino group of one amino acid reacts with carboxyl group of other amino acid, forming a **peptide bond**. Two amino acids can react together with the loss of water to form a **dipeptide**. Long strings of amino acids linked by peptide bonds are called **polypeptides**. In 1953 Fred Sanger first sequenced the Insulin protein (Figure 8.18 and 8.20 a and b).

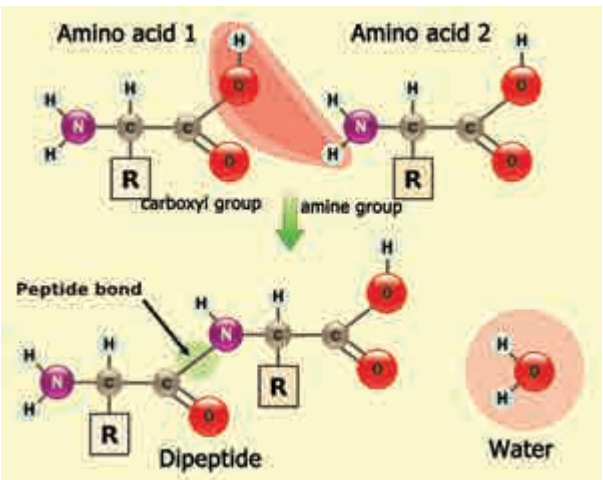


Figure 8.20(a): Amino acid reaction